Replit: Build, Run and Deploy an AI App

Replit is a browser-based coding environment. You write, run and publish an app without installing anything on your computer. This guide takes you from creating an account to deploying a small AI-powered app. Plans and prices are not included here, because they change; read the live pricing page (section 2) before you choose a plan.

1. Words you need first

Word	Meaning
Repl	A project: code, files and the running app.
Workspace	The browser editor with files, a console and a preview.
Secret	A private key, stored in the project, never written into the code.
Deployment	Publishing the app at its own public address.
Agent (Replit Agent)	An AI that builds or edits the app from your description.

2. Plans and prices: check the live page

Plans, included credits, deployment limits and prices change. For this guide, the plan names and prices were **not verified**, because the Replit pricing page could not be reached when this guide was written. Before you subscribe:

1. Open replit.com/pricing.
2. Note the plan name, the monthly and annual price, the included usage or credits, and whether deployments are included.
3. Write down the date you checked. Re-check before any decision.

> **How to choose:** start on the free tier to learn. Upgrade only when you need always-on deployments, more usage, or private projects for a team.

3. Create an account and your first project

1. Sign up at replit.com with a test account (not your work account, for a practice project).

2. Click **Create Repl**, choose a template (for example a Python or Node web app), and name it.
3. Wait for the workspace to load. Press **Run**.

You should see: the console prints a message, and the preview pane shows the app's page.

4. Add an AI feature with a secret key

An AI call needs an API key. Never put a key in the code. Store it as a **secret**.

1. Open the **Secrets** panel (lock icon) and add a secret named `AI_API_KEY` with a key from your provider's console. Use a test key with a spending limit.
2. In your code, read it from the environment: for Python, `os.environ["AI_API_KEY"]`; for Node, `process.env.AI_API_KEY`.
3. Make one call with a fixed prompt, print the answer, and check the token usage in the response.

```
import os
from some_ai_client import Client   # use your provider's official SDK

client = Client(api_key=os.environ["AI_API_KEY"])
prompt = "Write a 40-word product description for a masala dosa, warm tone."
reply = client.generate(prompt, max_tokens=80, temperature=0.7)
print(reply.text)
print("input tokens:", reply.usage.input_tokens, "output tokens:",
reply.usage.output_tokens)
```

Replace the client lines with your provider's real SDK. The point is the pattern: key in a secret, a capped output, and a logged usage count.

> **Never** paste an API key into the chat, a screenshot, a public repo or the code. If one leaks, delete it in the provider console and create a new one.

5. Build with the Agent (optional)

Replit's Agent can build the app from a description. Describe the app in one paragraph: who uses it, what it does, what it must not do. Review every change it makes. Ask it to explain changes you do not understand.

6. Deploy the app

1. Click **Deploy** (or the deployment panel) and choose the type that fits: a website, an autoscaling app, or a scheduled job.
2. Check the build and run commands it shows.
3. Deploy, then open the public URL and test one normal path and one error path.
4. Check the deployment's usage and logs after the first day.

Deployment options and limits change. Confirm them on the live documentation and pricing pages before you rely on them.

7. Test checklist

Test	Pass when
App runs in the workspace	No error in the console
Key is read from the secret	Code contains no key; the call works
Output length is capped	Answer stops at the limit you set
Deployed URL works	Normal path returns content
Bad input	A clear message, not a crash

8. Common problems

Problem	Fix
"Module not found"	Install the package from the package panel, then run again.
Key error at runtime	Check the secret name matches the code exactly.
App works in the workspace, fails when deployed	Check the run command and port in the deployment settings.
Costs rise suddenly	Check usage, add an output cap and a provider spending limit.

9. Quick check

1. Where should an API key be stored in Replit?
2. What is a deployment?

3. Why should you check the pricing page before choosing a plan?
4. What should you cap on every AI call?

Answers: 1. In Secrets, read from the environment. 2. Publishing the app at its own public address. 3. Plans and limits change. 4. Output length (max tokens).

10. Further reading

- Replit documentation: docs.replit.com.
- Replit pricing: replit.com/pricing (check the live page; the date you check matters).